# VS Code for the First Time

## Mac Edition

**The editor everyone uses.** Here's how to set it up properly.

`download` · `install` · `extensions` · `theme` · `shortcuts`

# Why VS Code?

It's free, fast, and runs everything — from HTML files to full Python projects.

### Free forever

Made by Microsoft, open source. No subscriptions, no paywalls.

### Extensions

Add support for any language or tool in two clicks from the marketplace.

### Fast & lightweight

Opens instantly. Handles single files and huge projects equally well.

### Built-in Terminal

Run commands without leaving the editor. Your code and terminal, side by side.

STEP 01

# Download & Install

1. Go to **code.visualstudio.com** — the big blue Download button auto-detects Mac.
2. Open the downloaded `.zip` file. It extracts to **Visual Studio Code.app** .
3. Drag **Visual Studio Code.app** into your `/Applications` folder. Don't skip this — running it from Downloads causes issues.
4. Open VS Code. If macOS says "unverified developer," go to **System Settings → Privacy & Security** and click Open Anyway.

**First launch tip:** VS Code will ask to install the `code` command in PATH. Click **Install** — this lets you open any folder from Terminal with `code .`

STEP 02

# Install 5 Essential Extensions

Open the Extensions panel with `⌘ Shift X`, then search by name.

🎨 **Prettier**
`esbenp.prettier-vscode`
Auto-formats your code on save. Never argue about indentation again.

🔍 **ESLint**
`dbaeumer.vscode-eslint`
Underlines JS/TS mistakes in real time before you even run the code.

🌈 **indent-rainbow**
`oderwat.indent-rainbow`
Colors each indentation level. Instantly spot misaligned blocks.

📁 **Material Icon Theme**
`pkief.material-icon-theme`
Adds file-type icons to the sidebar. Makes navigating projects much faster.

🤖 **GitHub Copilot**
`github.copilot`
AI autocomplete for code. Free for students, paid otherwise — worth it.

STEP 03

# Change Your Theme

The default theme is fine. These are better.

HOW TO CHANGE IT

Press `⌘ K` then `⌘ T` to open the theme picker. Arrow keys preview in real time.

OR VIA COMMAND PALETTE

Press `⌘ Shift P`, type `color theme`, hit Enter.

**One Dark Pro** Most popular dark theme
`zhuangtongfa.material-theme`

**GitHub Dark** Clean, familiar from GitHub
`github.github-vscode-theme`

**Catppuccin** Soft pastel dark theme
`catppuccin.catppuccin-vsc`

**Solarized Light** Best light theme, built-in
`no install needed`

STEP 04

# Enable Autosave

VS Code does **not** autosave by default. Fix this immediately.

OPTION A — MENU

Go to **File → Auto Save**. One click. Done. A checkmark appears when it's on.

OPTION B — SETTINGS

Press `⌘ ,` to open Settings. Search `autosave`. Set to **afterDelay** (1000ms default).

The dot on the tab means **unsaved changes**. Once autosave is on, you'll never see it again.

**Recommended setting:** `afterDelay` at 1000ms — saves one second after you stop typing. Fast enough to feel instant, without saving every single keystroke.

# Key Shortcuts Cheatsheet

| Shortcut | What it does | When to use it |
|---|---|---|
| ⌘ P | Quick Open — find any file | Jump between files instantly |
| ⌘ Shift P | Command Palette | Run any VS Code command by name |
| ⌘ ` | Toggle integrated Terminal | Run commands without leaving VS Code |
| ⌘ B | Toggle sidebar | More screen space when coding |
| ⌘ \ | Split editor | View two files side by side |
| ⌘ Shift F | Search across all files | Find anything in the whole project |
| ⌘ D | Select next occurrence | Multi-cursor rename in one go |
| ⌘ Z / ⌘ Shift Z | Undo / Redo | Your safety net — always works |
| ⌘ / | Toggle line comment | Comment out code in any language |
| ⌘ Shift X | Open Extensions panel | Install, manage, disable extensions |

# VS Code is ready.

# Start building.

You've got the editor, the extensions, and the shortcuts.

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